

in favour of Chaudhry as they are of a new-found peoples' power. Many civil society activists see this as a turning point in Pakistan's troubled judicial history and believe it may signal the beginning of an independent judiciary. The events of March 15 are also a testament to the restraint shown by Kayani who kept the army away from politics despite an environment many of his predecessors would have relished for a power-grab.

But despite the celebratory mood in the country, the crisis is far from over. The security situation in the country's north-west in particular continues to be troubling. In Swat, where the

qualification still lingers. Either of these could yet spell trouble for political reconciliation. Add to this the commitment by Sharif and civil society activists to continue to press for reforms that would, in effect, reduce Zardari to a ceremonial head of state. But perhaps the most troubling of all are the sky-high expectations of the public from Chaudhry who must also deal with a hodge podge of controversial political appointees to the judiciary post November 2, 2007. Any attempt to nullify them is likely to be complicated and meet resistance from Zardari.

In fact, for those who know Zardari, it seems inconceivable that he would take his humiliation lying down. He may have been forced to back down on the issue of the judges' restoration but he is known to harbour a grudge and many predict he would exact his revenge in other ways. He is also unlikely to forget the vitriol hurled against him by the Sharifs. In order to counter the boost the PML(N) has received from recent events in Punjab, the PPP would need to react politically aggressively to try and make up lost ground. None of this paints a rosy picture for the future.

For his part, Sharif is precisely where he wants to be. He has raised his political stature, has established his credentials as a "brave" and "principled" politician among the masses and is suddenly being taken more seriously by western governments, who had earlier been wary of his leanings towards the religious right. By strategically distancing himself from hardliners such as Qazi Hussain and Imran Khan—he called off the Long March without consulting them once the news of the judges'

SACKED CHIEF JUSTICE CHAUDHRY IS FELICITATED AFTER NEWS OF HIS REINSTATEMENT



AP PHOTO/ANJUM NAVEED

IFTIKHAR CHAUDHRY IS THE NEW ICON BUT THE WIDESPREAD CELEBRATION WAS AS MUCH FOR THE NEW-FOUND PEOPLES' POWER.

Government signed a 'peace agreement' with hardline Islamists, there are already indications of the latter using the Government's retreat to consolidate their writ in the area. There is widespread apprehension that the extremist violence plaguing tribal areas and parts of the Frontier Province may slowly be moving into Punjab. March 16 saw another suicide attack in Rawalpindi that killed 15 people. The Government is still looking for an economic bail-out from the IMF and increased aid-flows from the West, even as the West rethinks its strategy. The confrontation about who will control Punjab still exists and the issue of the Sharifs' dis-

restoration came through—he has shown the West and the military that he is a "mature" politician who can be trusted not to push things to chaotic extremes. Western commentators are already singing his praises as someone who could be useful in dealing with religious extremism. In Punjab, many of the rival PML(Q) party's legislators are willing to defect back to his party. His support base may still be limited to Punjab but as the home of 60 per cent of the country's population, it is a massive support base.

And, of course, all Nawaz Sharif needs to do is bide his time. ■